



L'art de L'échelle

THE ART OF SCALE: A STUDY ON DENNIS VILLENEUVE AND
IMPLIMENTATION OF SCALE AS A STORYTELLING TECHNIQUE

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Paper Topic

The Art of Scale: A study on Dennis Villeneuve and implementation of scale as a storytelling technique.

This paper discusses the different ways, scale can be used to set the mood for the audience. Dennis Villeneuve is famous for his critically acclaimed films like Dune Part 1 and 2, Blade Runner 2049, Arrival, Sicario, Prisoners, Enemy and more. In all his work he emphasizes the use of scale in setting the mood for the audience. Being influenced by his work, I have been learning to use the same approach in the landscapes I design and my work as a cinematic artist.

Dennis Villeneuve is a prominent Canadian director who employs visual scale not only as a spectacle but as a narrative and emotional way to amplify themes of insignificance, alienation and destiny. His use of framing, architecture and vastness in environments creates a mood of unease and awe that reflects the character's internal conflict and philosophical weight that the characters carry.

His work is what I consider a benchmark for storytelling through the lens. As a cinematic artist and level designer, my work includes creating vast environments representing a specific mood. The environments I make hold now value unless they are seen the way I want them to be seen and setting up cameras becomes an important part of it. The output must give out a sense of awe to the viewer and Villeneuve's work is the perfect benchmark for that. In all his work listed above, he uses scale differently and that makes every movie a different experience and helps me learn how these can be used in different settings.

What is Scale in cinematography?

Scale in cinematography refers to the importance of elements within a scene and often is in relation to the protagonist. The website NoFilmSchool refers to scale as the size of the narrative often manifested through the stakes of the story or the magnitude of the events portrayed.¹ Scale does not necessarily refer to the size of an object in the screen but the way it relates to the viewer and the characters on screen. It reflects the relationship between the character and the surrounding environment. The most common use of scale is usually the character in a relatively large landscape around which showcases insignificance and the larger-than-life journey that lays ahead. Villeneuve uses it in the same context but also adds the theme of internal struggle within the character. The same can be seen in shots with

¹ Hellerman, Jason. "Mastering Scope and Scale in Screenwriting"
<https://nofilmschool.com/scope-and-scale-in-screenwriting>

characters in confined spaces to create a feeling of tension and claustrophobia for the viewer.²

Relative Scale:

When working with scale as a cinematography tool, Relative Scale is a term that comes up quite often. We see it in every movie we have ever seen without ever knowing of its presence. As the name suggests, Relative scale refers to comparison of objects or characters in a scene in relation to each other. For example, the famous line from the movie franchise 'Star Wars' where Obi-Wan says "I have the high ground", the scene shows Obi-Wan on a higher surface and the antagonist is standing lower with a lava flowing in the background. Although one might think that the dialog pretty much conveys the same thing, the camera framing adds another layer. The protagonist on a higher ground signifies the morality of the character. This is further strengthened by the fact that the antagonist who killed innocent children has no morality, and the red-hot flowing lava signifies the rage that flows through Anakin, The antagonist.³

Another very important aspect of Scale in Cinematography is **Perspective**. This depends mainly on the lens choices made by the filmmaker. A wide-angle lens exaggerates depth and space which in turn makes the environment seem large and empty. On the other hand, a telephoto lens makes the image flat and elements in the scene appear closer together when they could be meters apart. These techniques help emphasize or de-emphasize subjects, control special relationships and create dreamlike hyper-realistic visuals.⁴

The thing about studying Scale as a storytelling technique is that once you learn about it, you see it everywhere. It elevates the storytelling experience to a whole other level.

² Brown, B. "Cinematography: Image making for cinematographers and directors."

³ A Still from Star Wars.

⁴ Brown, B. "Cinematography", Pages 136-140.

Notable works and use of scale:

Dune: He uses shots⁵ of massive sand dunes, worms and desert environments in contrast to the main character Paul Atreides who is insignificant to the empire he must protect and fight for. It's the destiny Paul must confront. Dune switches from shots showing colossal landscapes to tightly framed personal moments to highlight the stakes. These contrasts between shots are helpful in storytelling and everything just flows for the viewer.

Blade Runner 2049: Shots of the protagonist in his environments including deserted landscapes and cyberpunk city represent his isolation from society and questions of his own identity. The scale also sets the tone and mood of the film. This film uses scale as a commentary to artificial identity of the protagonist. There are a lot of shots in the film with massive architecture with almost sterile environment. This adds an additional layer of existential loneliness.

Enemy: In Enemy, the scale isn't used to depict vastness, but it is used to amplify the feeling of being overwhelmed by internal fears. In one of the scenes, the disproportionate size of the spider can be seen to destabilize the viewer emotionally. It's surreal and just a metaphor for his wife, who he viewed as less than human. The use of scale in this is almost oppressive and acts like a psychological trap. The film features regular residential complexes that are portrayed cold and massive which mimic the entrapment and confusion which haunts the protagonist.

Arrival: In Arrival, Villeneuve uses the colossal scale of the alien spaceship to not only show the larger-than-life spaceship but to create a sense of humility and awe. The humans around it look puny and insignificant. Multiple shots inside the ships show the space that defies gravity and orientation and are used to represent non-linear perception of time. The scale in this movie is non-Euclidean to reinforce the fact that the characters are dealing with a higher intelligence.

As seen in the above examples, Villeneuve likes to play with scale differently, but the outcomes of these shots are key to his storytelling. They are visually stunning but have a deeper meaning behind them that is easier for the viewer to understand. It's simple yet complex. Using his technique of scale requires a vision that the artist should have complete understanding of.

Personal Work: My work has been hugely inspired by his work and over the years, I have made several cinematics on vast landscapes. Like Villeneuve, I focus on making shots that create a mood for the viewer. Some of my works are shown below as I try to learn more about shot composition and scale of environments.



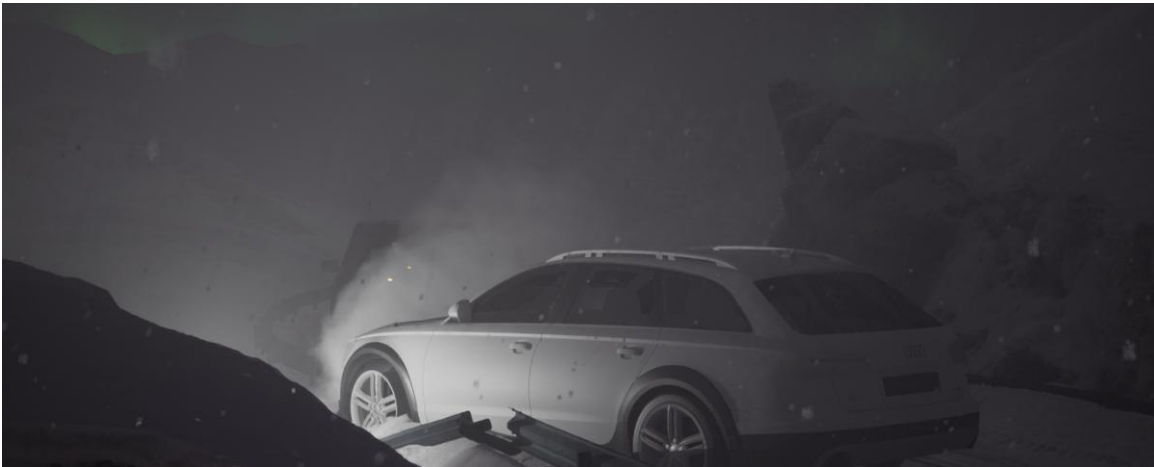
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⁶ Singh, Bhanu. 2023 "Storm Walker"

⁷ Singh, Bhanu. 2023 "Icelandic Landscape"



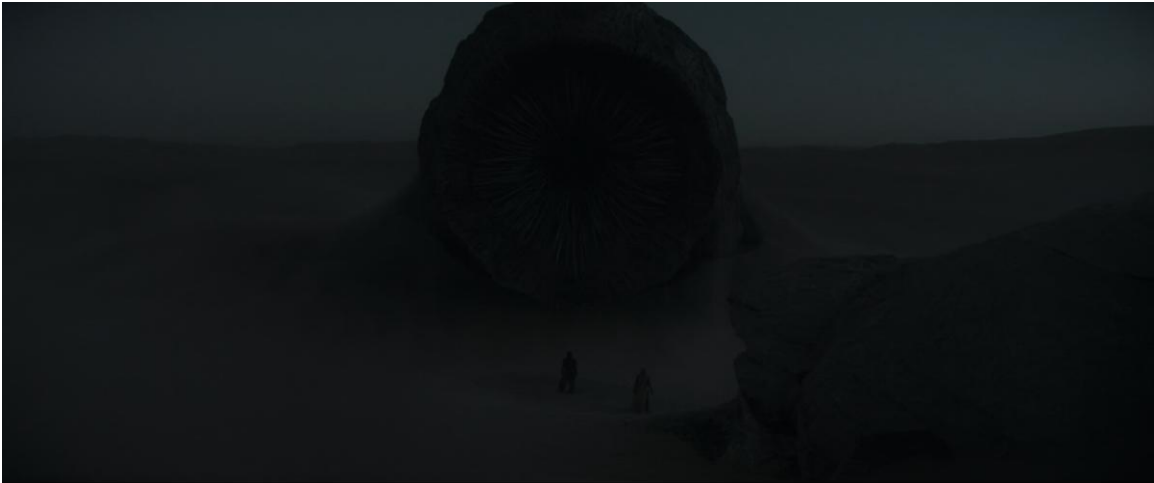
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⁸ Singh, Bhanu. 2023 "Storm Walker"

⁹ Singh, Bhanu. 2022 "Shoorveer" Disney+



¹⁰ Villeneuve, Denis. 2021 "Dune: Part-1" USA: Warner Bros. Pictures.



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¹¹ Villeneuve, Denis. 2017 *“Blade Runner 2049”* USA: Warner Bros. Pictures, 2017.

¹² Villeneuve, Denis. 2013 *“Enemy”*, Entertainment One.



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¹³ Villeneuve, Denis. 2016 "Arrival", Paramount Pictures.

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<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iWecEjVP61E>

Cover photo by digital_cinematography_ on Instagram

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